

Four Poems

Woke Through Thunder

King of the Forest

Open the Final Door

Tool of the Trade

Steve Gutsche

2026

Woke Through Thunder

— *Steve Gutsche* —

Dirt road living under a borrowed sky
Creek runs high and the coffee's running dry
Pocket full of nothing, head full of plans
Just light playing tricks through these weathered hands

• • •

I've been down but I ain't under
Slept through lightning, woke through thunder
Bent by the weight of a world I didn't make
Laughing at the beauty of a dream that's fake

• • •

The suits and the systems and the locked front doors
Are just furniture arrangements on imaginary floors
We're all just characters who forgot we wrote the play
Arguing about the plot while the author looks away

• • •

What is money but a number we agreed to fear
What is struggle but the universe just shifting gear
The creek don't know my debts, the rain don't know my name
And the mountain smiles at everyone who plays the game

• • •

Rich man, poor man, beggar at the door
We're all just wearing costumes we've forgotten to ignore
The billionaire and the bush camp and the space between

Are pixels in a painting that nobody's really seen

• • •

I've been down but I ain't under

Slept through lightning, woke through thunder

Looked behind the curtain at the wizard running things

Found a kid with a flashlight and a handful of imaginings

• • •

They built the cage so slowly that we thought it was a home

Hung mirrors on the bars so we'd feel less alone

Called the illusion freedom, called the contract choice

Taught us all to sing along and called it our own voice

• • •

Nothing on the news is new, nothing in the store is real

Every want they sold us was a wound they helped us feel

The game was rigged before you learned the name of every piece

But even knowing that somehow the hunger doesn't cease

• • •

That's the genius of the trick, the beauty of the trap

You can see the strings above you and still fall through the gap

Awake inside the dreaming, laughing at the cost

Knowing that you're found my friend the moment that you're lost

• • •

So build your castles carefully or don't build them at all

The joke's the same whether you rise or whether you fall

The construct holds us tenderly like water holds the rain

Until we pour ourselves back into everything again

• • •

And still the morning comes around

Still the fire makes its sound

Still something in the joke says rise

And wink at the light behind your eyes

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King of the Forest

— *Steve Gutsche* —

Didn't know it was a game
Didn't know there were rules
Just woke up one morning
In a world that nobody chose
Came in ancient but an infant
No map and no plan
Just a blank slate and a question
And two empty hands

• • •

A spark of the divine chose to play
Left his memory at the door
A babe in the woods
Becomes king of the forest
When he remembers what he came here for

• • •

Rules and I never did get along
Trouble knew my name
Never went looking for the storm
The storm came just the same
Everything's a lesson
Trouble most of all
The harder the classroom
The higher you fall

. . .

Built the cage and called it living
Called the chain a path
The joke's been there the whole time
Just waiting on the laugh
Funny thing about a rigged game
Once you see it you can't unsee
Funnier still when you realize
You designed the whole damn thing

. . .

Saw through it quiet one morning
Not a crash just a click
Everything I thought was real
Just a magician's trick
One law left when the smoke cleared
Older than the game
Written in the creeks and canyon walls
Before the world had a name

. . .

A spark of the divine chose to play
Left his memory at the door
A babe in the woods
Becomes king of the forest
He remembers what he came here for
He finally remembers
What he came here for

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Open the Final Door

— *Steve Gutsche* —

Stepping into the game
Deaf dumb and blind
Feeling for the edges
Leave the map behind

• • •

Indoctrination
School of control
Trying to shape you
Mold your very soul
Giving you the answers
Just the wrong ones
But if you know you know

• • •

They say patience is a virtue
But the waiting never ends
I can wait forever
Playing their silly game
Plans are poised and ready
Time is an illusion anyway

• • •

Just a stranger in a strange land
A stranger in a strange land

• • •

Have to really wonder
What it's all for
Stop looking—
The answer isn't out there
It's sitting inside
Waiting for recognition
Knocking at the door

• • •

Looking in the mirror
Seeing the light behind my eyes
Knowing this is just a visit
Past present future
All fading into one

• • •

Looking in the mirror
Seeing the real you
The source of everything is calling

• • •

Open the final door...

Tool of the Trade

— *Steve Gutsche* —

Pocket full of nothing, still I know the score
Money's just a hammer, not what hammers are for
You can drive it like a nail or you can let it rust
Either way the sun comes up and turns it back to dust

• • •

Some men clutch it tighter when they feel the cold
That fear becomes the cage that keeps them from the gold
It's a frequency like sunlight, like the rain, like the wind
Close your fist against it and it won't come in

• • •

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone
Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

• • •

Paper promises printed by the ton
Backed by nothing but the faith of everyone
They print it thin and call the fiction wealth
While gold and silver keep their counsel in stealth

• • •

Gold remembers every hand that held it there
Silver keeps its counsel, patient, holding fair
Paper burns and fades to empty air

Just a promise long past due and wearing thin

. . .

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone
Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

. . .

I know the signal, I know the tune
Still working on my receiver
The miles between them teaching me
Still burning off the distance
Yeah, burning off the distance

. . .

The river doesn't hoard itself, it just keeps moving through
What you put out finds you, that much I know is true
A roof over a stranger, given not from fear but grace
Money finds the open hand and returns in faith

. . .

It's a tool not a treasure, a road not a home
Enough to keep you moving, enough to not be alone
Open hands can catch it, closed ones turn it away
Just a tool of the trade boys, meant to flow not stay

. . .

Just a tool of the trade boys
Meant to flow not stay

Just a tool of the trade

Flowing on its way

Gold remembers

Silver knows

Paper fades

But value flows

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